



MODULE 6

Emotional Self-Regulation

What do your emotions do to your players — even when you think you're saying nothing?

CORE THEORY

Emotional contagion (Hatfield, Cacioppo & Rapson, 1994) shows that people unconsciously adopt each other's emotions through micro-expressions, tone of voice, and body language. As a coach you are the dominant emotional broadcaster in your group: your tension becomes their tension, your calm becomes their calm. Neuropsychologically this is known as limbic resonance — your players' amygdalae literally mirror yours. Self-regulation is not a soft skill; it is a performance variable.

Source: Hatfield et al. (1994) · Lewis, Amini & Lannon (2000) · Gross (1998) · Goleman (1995)

"You cannot hide your emotions from people who depend on you. They feel everything."

— Daniel Goleman

"The calm coach creates calm athletes. The anxious coach creates anxious athletes. Always."

— Steve Peters

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 What are your three biggest emotional triggers as a coach? (E.g.: losing, lack of effort, mistakes under pressure.)
- 2 How do you physically notice that tension is building during a game? What does that do to your body language?
- 3 When did you last have an emotional reaction you later regretted? What was the trigger?
- 4 How do you prepare yourself for an emotionally demanding game or training? Do you have a routine?
- 5 What do your players do when you are tense? Consciously observe this over the coming weeks.

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **The Chimp Paradox**
Steve Peters
Why: How the emotional brain works — and how to manage it. Used by Team GB and Chris Hoy. Practical and accessible.
- **Emotional Intelligence**
Daniel Goleman
Why: The scientific foundation of EQ. Read Part 2: why emotions are contagious and how you manage that as a leader.
- **Performing Under Pressure**
Weisinger & Pawliw-Fry
Why: Concrete: how pressure destroys performance and how to reverse that. Includes toolkit for coaches.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **The Hand Model of the Brain**
Daniel Siegel
[youtube.com/watch?v=gm9CIJ74Oxw](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gm9CIJ74Oxw)
Teach this model to your players too. Understanding how the brain works under pressure is liberating.
- **Managing Your Emotions as a Coach**
Steve Peters (Sport Interview)
[youtube.com/results?search_query=steve+peters+chimp+paradox+coaching](https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=steve+peters+chimp+paradox+coaching)
How Peters works with elite athletes on emotional control in the coach.

**PODCASTS**

- **The High Performance Podcast**
Episode on performance anxiety and pressure regulation in coaches
thehighperformancepodcast.com
- **Finding Mastery**
Episode with Michael Gervais — self-regulation as the foundation of coaching
findingmastery.com

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Develop a 5-minute pre-game routine that emotionally calibrates you. Box breathing (4-4-4-4), body scan, or an intention sentence. Test it for 3 consecutive games.

My personal emotional trigger as a coach I want to work on:
